

Chicago Tribune



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TUESDAY, DECEMBER 17, 2024

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

MICHAEL MADIGAN TRIAL

Acevedo takes stand as reluctant witness

Feds: Ex-legislator was paid by AT&T, ComEd after retiring

By Jason Meisner and Megan Crepeau
Chicago Tribune

After weeks of legal wrangling over his testimony, former state Rep. Edward Acevedo had barely taken his seat on the witness stand in the Michael Madigan corruption trial Monday when it became abundantly clear he was a reluctant participant in the proceedings.

“Sir, you did not want to testify here today, did you?” asked Assistant U.S. Attorney Amarjeet Bhachu.

“Um, no, I did not,” Acevedo answered in a matter-of-fact tone.

So began Acevedo’s long-awaited turn as a government witness in Madigan’s trial, where the former Chicago police officer and House assistant majority leader is central to allegations that AT&T Illinois and Commonwealth Edison funneled hundreds of thousands of dollars in do-nothing consulting contracts to Acevedo and other Madigan loyalists in return for the speaker’s help with legislation in Springfield.

Prosecutors allege Acevedo, 61, was paid a total of \$142,500 by AT&T and ComEd after retiring from the Illinois House in 2017, even though he was not expected to do much of anything for the money.

But questioning on that topic turned quickly contentious Monday when Acevedo claimed he had in fact attended meetings on behalf of AT&T and even given oral reports to Stephen Selcke, a former AT&T governmental affairs executive, about his thoughts on how the Latino caucus came down on certain legislation.

“I told you, I went to hearings,” Acevedo said at one point during a tense back-and-forth with Bhachu. “I went to meetings and I was always telling Steve Selcke what was happening. ... I would meet him at the rail. ... He would always ask me how I thought the Latino legislators were going.”

Acevedo also claimed he and his sons, Alex and Michael, would have meetings “on the side” where they “were discussing the legislation that they were trying to push through.”

That prompted Bhachu to confront Acevedo with his previous statement before a federal grand jury where he said he’d actually done no work for the utility. After reading a part of his

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Robots make the salads

Sweetgreen in Willis Tower is launching an assembly line of robotic chefs preparing bowls of everything from Kale Caesar to Hummus Crunch. **Business**

‘Tune in and turn it up’

Greg Kot and Jim DeRogatis’ long-running radio program “Sound Opinions” has deep roots in Chicago. Their 1,000th episode is in January. **Arts & Living**

Countries brace for migrants

Honduras and other Central American countries are preparing for a potential influx of vulnerable migrants — and are ill-prepared to handle it. **Nation & World**



Chicago Aldermen Brendan Reilly, 42nd, from left, Ray Lopez, 15th, and Scott Waguespack, 32nd, talk before Monday’s City Council meeting at City Hall. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Aldermen finally give approval to mayor’s ’25 Chicago budget

Council OKs \$17.1 billion spending plan, avoiding shutdown of city government

By Alice Yin, A.D. Quig and Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson’s 2025 budget plan made it through the City Council on Monday, a hard-fought victory for the mayor that spares City Hall an unprecedented government shutdown after one of Chicago’s most chaotic budget cycles in recent years.

Aldermen voted 27-23 to approve Johnson’s \$17.1 billion spending plan for next year

after his team proposed a fourth version that completely eliminated his property tax hike in the face of widespread aldermanic objections. The revenue package containing a mix of other tax and fee hikes also passed 27-23.

In a post-council news conference, the mayor applauded the conclusion of his second budget but remained coy on what would be different when it’s time to iron out his 2026 spending plan.

“With this budget, we put yet another down payment towards a better, stronger and safer future

for the working people and families who call this city their home,” Johnson told reporters in the early evening. “We passed a budget that does not cut services, does not cut jobs, does not raise property taxes and sustains key investments.”

It was the closest budget vote a Chicago mayor has faced in decades but nonetheless a relief for Johnson given the looming Dec. 31 deadline to pass a budget or risk government services shutting down and the city’s financial standing suffering. His opponents, however, will likely use the thin margin as another opening to pounce on Johnson’s leadership abilities after the last few

months of clumsy budget negotiations and high-profile personnel scandals spelled a new nadir for the freshman mayor’s political capital.

In the end, the 2025 budget process that began with the mayor presenting a staggering \$300 million property tax increase concluded with a winning package that brought that number down to zero. Instead, Johnson’s team on Sunday offered a combination of cuts and about \$40 million in debt savings to plug in the new hole that came from nixing his most recent \$68.5 million property tax hike.

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Students board a bus as they leave a shelter after a shooting at Abundant Life Christian School in Madison, Wis., on Monday. **MORRY GASH/AP**

Teen student kills two at Wisconsin school

Police chief: Shooter also dead in ‘sad, sad day’ for city, country

By Scott Bauer
Associated Press

MADISON, Wis. — A teenage student opened fire with a handgun Monday at a private Christian school in Wisconsin’s capital, killing a teacher and another teenager during the final week before Christmas

break. Madison police said the shooter was dead by apparent suicide when officers arrived.

The shooter also wounded others at Abundant Life Christian School, including two students who were in critical condition and four with less serious injuries, Madison police Chief Shon Barnes said. Two of the hospitalized victims have been released, he said.

“I’m feeling a little dismayed now, so close to Christmas,” Barnes said. “Every child,

every person in that building is a victim and will be a victim forever. ... We need to figure out and try to piece together what exactly happened.”

The shooter was a 17-year-old female student, a law enforcement official told The Associated Press. The official spoke on the condition of anonymity.

Barnes declined to give details about the shooter. With a few rare exceptions, a 17-year-

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Columbia College Chicago to cut programs

School to lay off about 30 faculty next fall amid budget troubles

By Rebecca Johnson
Chicago Tribune

Columbia College Chicago plans to cut 11 undergraduate and graduate programs and eliminate up to 25 faculty positions next academic year to “promote future growth centered around student success” amid ongoing budget trouble and declining enrollment, the school announced Monday evening.

“We wanted to make sure that our curriculum reflects what industry needs are and what parents and students are asking for,” interim President Jerry Tarrer told the Tribune. “Those are the primary considerations ... to ensure that for the short and long haul we are providing a curriculum that will help to deliver professional success for young creatives who choose Columbia.”

The school will decrease its number of undergraduate degrees from 58 to 33 by consolidating some and cutting others, Tarrer said. They plan to entirely discontinue four undergraduate and seven graduate programs, which will impact about 175 students.

The undergraduate majors set

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